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Research Skills complete

Research Proposal Writing Skills (Mount Kenya University)

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DECTE/DPTE UPGRADING PROGRAMS 2021- RESEARCH SKILLS

Definition of Research:

- Is the systematic process of gathering, interpreting and reporting information or data.
- It is the scientific process of collecting, presenting, analyzing and reporting information with an aim of getting solutions to the problem.
- A scientific investigation to produce new knowledge.
- A diligent (well thought out) study to discover factors to solve a problem. - An original contribution to the existing stock of knowledge

IMPORTANCE OF RESEARCH IN TEACHING AND LEARNING

i. Helps to identify constrains or challenges to the implementation of educational programs
ii. Helps in the development of new knowledge that can be used to improve educational content and methodologies.
iii. Helps to provide knowledge on how to improve parenting and care of children both at home and in educational institutions.
iv. It provides useful data necessary for the improvement of educational programs
v. Useful for decision making and formation of policies.
vi. Helps in designing methodology which helps to improve teaching and learning.
vii. Provides data which helps in understanding children and predicting behavior for purposes of early intervention.
viii. Helps in finding answers and solutions to problems in educational institutions.
ix. Helps in designing educational policies.
x. Helps to identify children with special needs in education.
xi. Provides data that is relevant for practical guidance in solving immediate problems of human relations in educational institutions.
xii. It provides an avenue /way/an outlet for new ideas or insights
xiii. It provides data necessary for the development of new theories. xiv. It is a career and source of livelihood for professionals in research. xv. Leads to development of skills in recording, observing and reporting.

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CHARACTERISTICS OF RESEARCH.

1. It is systematic
   - It follows a well-structured process and has definite or clear rules.
2. It is logical
   - It follows steps that are clearly defined from the beginning to the end.
3. It is empirical
   - It involves use of concrete data collected from field or experiment that has been carried out. Conclusions obtained are based on evidence gathered.
4. It is deductive
   - This means that the researchers is able to analyze and interpret data collected in order to bring out a better and clear understanding of the problem.
5. It is replicable
   - Research that has been carried out in one place can again be carried out in other similar places, using the same instruments and the same methodology.
   - The research results can be verified by replicating the study and thereby building a sound base for decisions.
6. It is scientific
   - Research is concerned with explanations which can be proved/are verifiable.
   - The results or findings of a research are usually subjected to tests which are treated objectively regardless of pre- conceived notions.
7. Controlled
   - Research allows for little interference and flexibility.
   - The research process is characterized by clear and explicit decisions as to what, how and when to observe.
8. Valid and verifiable
   - Conclusions from your research findings are correct and are verifiable by you and others.

PURPOSE OF RESEARCH.

i. To discover answers to questions through application of scientific procedures. It is to find out the truth (which is hidden) and which has not been discovered.

ii. To gain familiarity with phenomenon or to achieve new insights into it (these are exploratory or formulative research studies) , to describe and explain phenomenon.

iii. To portray accurately the characteristics of a particular individual , situations or a group. (these are the descriptive research studies)

iv. To determine the frequency with which something occurs or with which it is associated with something else.(these are the diagnostic research studies)

v. To test a hypothesis of causal relationship between variables.(these are the hypothesis testing research studies)

vi. To discover knowledge i.e discovery of new facts and their applications to generate new knowledge.

vii. To enable prediction by determining or establishing trends. viii. To enable the development of theories.

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Generally, the purpose of research is to review or synthesize existing knowledge, investigate existing situations or problems, provide solution to problems, explore and analyses issues to construct or create new procedures and to explain new phenomenon.

TYPES OF RESEARCH

1) **Analytical research**
   - Refers to when a researcher has to use facts or information already available, analyze the information to make a critical evaluation of the facts/material/information.
   - Analytical research uses available data to suggest or explain why or how something is happening eg **The underlying causes of increased referrals in teacher training colleges.**

2) **Descriptive research/Ex post factor research**
- These refer to surveys and fact-findings studies of different kinds.
- It is a description of the state of affairs as it is at present or at the time of study.
- The researcher has no control over the variables. He or she can only report what has happened or what is happening eg **Frequency of shopping** , **Preferences of people** etc.
- Studies that aim at discovering causes of problems in society are also categorized as descriptive research.
- Descriptive research can also be used to identify and clarify the elements or characteristics of the subject under investigation, e.g **Number of days lost because of corona at work place or learning institutions.**

3) **Applied research**
- It aims at finding a solution for an immediate problem facing a society, an industry or a business organization.
- The findings have direct application to the concerned people and their problems. It is aimed at solving particular existing problems rather than acquire new knowledge
- It refers to research aimed at making certain conclusions about a concrete social or business problem.
- It is a research to identify social, economic or political trends that may affect a particular institution e.g **Marketing research**, **Evaluation research** are examples of applied research.
- The central aim of applied research is to discover a solution for some pressing practical problems.
- The aim is to deal with a particular issue, e.g **Reduce child mortality**, **Improve child growth and development**, **Maximize parental involvement in children education**.

4) **Empirical research**
- It is a data based research which comes up with conclusions that can be verified by observation or experiment.
- It is also known as experimental type of research.

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- Facts are based on fast hand information, at their source which are then analysed to arrive at conclusions.
- Empirical research is appropriate when a proof is sought that certain variables affect other variables in some way.
- The research involves formulation of hypothesis or guess as to the probable results.

5) **Quantitative research / Approach**
- It is based on the quantity measurements of some characteristics.
- This type of research is applicable in areas that can be expressed in terms of quantities.
- It involves generation of data in quantitative forms.
- Measures such as mode and mean are used to describe data
- It involves large number of respondents
- **Psychological tests and achievement tests** are the main examples

6) **Qualitative research/ Approach**.
- It is concerned with subjective assessment of attitudes, opinions and behavior.
- This type of research generates results either in non-quantitative form or in the form which is not subjected to vigorous quantitative analysis.
- Qualitative research is especially important in behavioral sciences for which the aim is to understand the underlying motives of human behavior.
- Methods include: **Interviews, Focus Group Discussions and Historical profiles**

7) **Basic research**.
- The main aim of basic research is to build knowledge.
- It has no immediate application or use at the time of research. It may probe answers to questions like: **How did children learn to walk in the past?** **What teaching methods were used in the last decade?**
- It helps to increase one‟s knowledge on a given issue.
- Basic research leads to full understanding of the subject under study.
- It is meant to enrich an organized body of knowledge, and does not necessarily produce results of immediate practical value.
- It involves development of theories or generalization about human behavior.

8) **Action research**
- It is almost the same as applied research.
- It is mostly qualitative and participative in nature
- It adds to scientific knowledge and provides information for planning and implementation of project and programmes.
- The type of research is geared towards solving educational problems through application of scientific methods.
- It is concerned with diagnosing a problem in a specific context and attempting to solve it in that particular context.
- It is action oriented e.g **Making children in a class more active**, **Modifying teaching methods**, **How a farmer can improve crop production**

9) **Exploratory research**.

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- Exploratory research is undertaken when few or no previous studies exist in that area or topic.
- The aim is to look for patterns, hypothesis or ideas that can be tested and will form the basis for further research.
- Typical research techniques would include case studies, observation or reviews of previous related studies and data.

RESEARCH APPROACHES.

i. Quantitative Approach
- Involves generation of data in quantitative form.
- The data is in a form in which can be subjected to vigorous quantitative analysis
- This approach is further classified into inferential approach and experimental approach.

a) Inferential approach.
-In this approach , a sample of the population is studied or observed to determine its characteristics. Such characteristics are identified and then generalized for the whole population.

b) Experimental approach.
-In this case, some variables are manipulated to observe their effect on the other variables.

ii. Qualitative Approach.
- It is concerned with the subjective assessment of attitudes, opinions and behavior.
- This research generates results in non-quantitative form or in a form which is not subjected to vigorous quantitative analysis.
- Focus group interviews and in-depth interviews are used to collect data.

iii. Mixed Approach.

CATEGORIES OF RESEARCH.

There are two main categories of research based on time:

a) Cross- Sectioned Research.
The research is confined to a single time-period.

b) Longitudinal Research.
The research is carried out over several time periods.

RESEARCH PROBLEM.

- A research problem refers to difficulty which the researcher experiences in the context of either a theoretical or practical situation and wants to obtain a solution.
- A research problem should meet the following conditions;
  i) There must be an individual, group of people or an organization.
  ii) There must be some objectives to be attained.
  iii) There must be alternative means (or courses of action) for obtaining the objective that one wants to attain.
  iv) There must be doubt in the mind of the researcher with regard to the selection of alternatives.
  v) There must be some environment (In this case teaching and learning enviroment)

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POSSIBLE SOURCES OF RESEARCH PROBLEMS IN TEACHING AND LEARNING ENVIROMENT.

2. **The Media**.
   - Issues reported in the media can be the basis for a research problem, e.g Radio , TV , Newspapers , Journals. Such problems are usually discussed in public. i.e It is a problem that is wide and is affecting the society/community or a majority of people.

3. **Personal Experience**.
   - The relationship among peers in the staffroom may be a source of research problem.
   - The school environment or the class environment can provide a problem worth research.
   - It can be an observation of puzzling, controversial or disturbing occurences.
   - It may also stem from questions that the researcher keeps asking himself or herself.

4. **Discussion with research experts on problematic areas.**
   - Discussion with experienced and informed people can help generate topics which can be researched.

5. **Replication.**
   - This involves carrying out a study that had been done previously to find out whether findings (conclusions drawn) hold over time and across regions.
   - In replication, a researcher may review a successful research or experiment, disagree with the results, the tests used or the methodology used and consequently decide to refine the research process or retest the hypothesis to determine if the findings can be sustained overtime or across regions.

6. **Previous research.**
   - Previous research usually indicates areas for further research and therefore can be a source of research problem.

7. **Existing literature in the field of education**.
   - Weekly, monthly or annual publications by the ministry of education and other bodies can be a source of research problem .These publications may avail some areas of interest that can be studied.

8. **Existing theories.**
   - Theories encompass organized body of concepts, generalizations and principles that can be subjected to investigation. e.g one may study **The relevance or application of Jean Piaget's theory of cognitive development** or **other theories explaining child growth and development in the context of Education.**

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IMPORTANCE OF STATING A RESEARCH PROBLEM.

In a proposal, research problem is usually stated and titled as "Statement of the problem". It is important to state the research problem because:

1) It gives direction to the research process.
2) It gives insight into the gravity of the issue that needs to be investigated.
3) It strengthens the justification for conducting a study because it avails information that shows the necessity for conducting the study.
4) It broadly illuminates the scope of the study because it captures the attitudes of investigation in aresearch.

CHARACTERISTICS OF A GOOD STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM.

i) Should be clearly written /precise to capture the readers interest.

ii) Should be specific i.e should be relevant to the topic. iii. Should indicate the scope of the study i.e the variables of the investigation. iv. Should give the purpose of the study/research.

v. Should be convincing enough. vi. The statement should show the urgency, importance and the need for the study.

STEPS TO FOLLOW WHEN SELECTING A TOPIC OF RESEARCH.

1. Identify a broad area of interest such as Education, Health or Nutrition of pupils. These areas may include:
   i. Early childhood development.
   ii. Health Education / Services.
   iii. Primary school Education. iv. School feeding programme.
   v. Free Primary School Education.
   vi. Nutrition status of children. vii. Television instruction/ Radio instruction programme. viii. Team teaching. ix. Homework.
   x. Life skills.
   xi. Teacher morals.
   xii. School/classroom environment.

2. Identify the specific area within the broad area that will form the basis of the study. Specific areas might include;
   - Methods of teaching in primary schools.
   - Parenting styles.
   - Institutional or learning materials.
   - Play in primary schools.
   - Immunization of children.
   - Feeding programs in schools. (challenges or sources of funds) - Roles of teachers and parents in feeding programe.
   - Emerging social issues in the implementation of CBC in grade 3.
   - Challenges or benefits of inclusivity in grade 1 to 3.

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- Challenges of assessing learners in grade 1 to 3 in the current CBC education programe.
- Challenges or advantages of ICT inclusion in facilitating learning in grade 1 to 3.
- Assessment in the level of preparedness for the integration of ICT for curriculum delivery in public teacher training colleges.

FEASIBILITY OF A RESEARCH PROBLEM.

- A research problem should be that which can be conducted within the competence of the researcher and available resources.

CRITERIA FOR DETERMINING THE FEASIBILITY OF A RESEARCH PROBLEM.

i. It should be within the researcher‟s interest to study it. It is not proper to allocate researched topics to the students .
ii. The topic should be such that it can be conducted or researched within the allocated time / time frame.
iii. Timing of data collection should be considered for some research problems.
iv. Consider the availability of the subject, object or cases with the desired characteristics.
v. Availability of the required facilities and equipments. e.g laboratories , open spaces , computers, telephones , photocopying machines, etc.
vi. The availability of the required financial resources. The researcher should make the research budget in advance.
vii. The research problem should be that which the researcher can conduct with relative ease way procedures that he/she is familiar with.
viii. A feasible research problem should uphold ethical consideration of research as protecting the subjects from harm and avoiding exposing them to unfair demand or intruding on their privacy.

CRITERIA FOR SELECTING A RESEARCH PROBLEM.

1. **Interest**.
   - It should be a topic /subtopic that is important to you and you are interested in the topic.This will enable you to read widely. However, this does not mean that you research on trivial issues.
2. **Size**.
   - Research topics is often too large for satisfactory results to be obtained. - Reduce the topics to a small and manageable research.
3. **Economy**.
   - Consider time for the research and money involved.
4. **Researcher's capability and limitations.**
   - It is important to have people willing to support throughout the research, to suggest alternative approaches, assist in classification of issues etc.
5. **Uniqueness**.
   - Do not spend time and money researching a problem if the answer to the problem already exists.

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- Do not duplicate studies.
- However you may want to pursue a study similar to one already in existence but change the methods used , modify the design or use different sample or choose to perform a different statistical analysis (replication)

PROPOSAL WRITING - PARTS/ COMPONENTS OF THE PROPOSAL

Format of the preliminary pages of the proposal.

1. This page should not be paginated.
   All wordings should be single spaced and in capital letters (upper case).
   The items in the cover page should be in bold and font size 12, Times New Roman and arranged in the sequence as below:
   - **Title** - should be informative and not more than 20 words, presented at the top. - Do not use abbreviations or repetitions of words.
   - Do not begin the title with ambiguous phrases such as „Factors influencing…..‟ instead, be specific eg economic factors, social factors, psychological factors etc.
   - The title should bring out the scope, the independent and dependent variables, site of study, target population.
   - Full names of student
   - Admission number or index number should be below the name.
   - Below the students details is the proposal statement that should be presented e.g ***A research proposal submitted……..***

2. Declaration.
   This is the second page after preliminary section where the student should clearly state;
   - Whether the proposal has been or has not been submitted to any other college, university or other institution of higher learning for purposes of obtaining academic qualification.
   - Then the student signs above his/her name and admission or index number followed by the date.

   Example

   DECLARATION

   I, the undersigned, affirm that this is my original work and has not been submitted to any other, College, University, other than Kamagambo Adventist Teachers Training College for the academic award of Diploma in Primary Teacher Education.
   Signed: _____ Date: _____
   Grace Jepkoech
   ADM NO. 643896

3. Acknowledgements.
   The section acknowledges all individuals, groups of people or institutions that the student feels indebted to for the support they rendered during his/her research. Eg study respondents, family members etc.

   ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

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I wish to thank my supervisor Stephen M. N. for his immense support in writing this Research Report. I would like to sincerely thank my beloved family, friends and my fellow students for their understanding and continuous encouragement throughout my execution of this Report. Above all, I pay gratitude to Almighty God for the gift of life and good health, for giving me strength and wisdom to prepare this project report

4. Table of content.
   The table must capture all the major sections of the proposal at various levels (subheadings or tittles)
   The spacing should be 1.5

   Example

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5. List of tables.
   Indicate the page in which particular table appears.
   List of table should be in its own page.
   eg Table 1.1 - Means that the table is number 1 in chapter 1.

LIST OF TABLES
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33 Table 4.3 Extent of Leadership Affecting Absenteeism 34

6. List of figures.
   Should be in its own page.
   Should indicate the page where the figures appear.
   eg Figure 3.1 - Means that the figure is in number 1 in chapter 3.

LIST OF FIGURES
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Figure 4.3 Ages of Respondents..... 29

7. Abbreviations and Acronyms. eg

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CBS : Central Bureau of Statistics **EU**
: European Union.
FGOs : Focus Group Discoveries.
FAO : Food and Agriculture Organization.

8. Operational definition of terms and key concepts.
   The terms used should be arranged alphabetically.
   The definition helps the researcher to communicate to readers clearly.

9. Abstract.
   - This section presents the compact summary of the study and highlights the new knowledge contributed by the researcher.
   - It provides the study background, the statement of the problem, purpose and objectives of the study, the scope, theoretical or conceptual frame work , research methods, expectations of the research and implications of the research.
   - Description of the method may include the research design, procedures, the sample size, instruments of data collection and how data will be analyzed.
   - Should be single- spaced, one block paragraphed and should not be more than 500 words in length. The paragraph should not exceed one page.

Sample

ABSTRACT

The purpose of the study was set to investigate the factors influencing teachers' absenteeism in public primary schools. The study aimed at addressing the following specific research objectives; to determine the extent to which socio-demographics characteristics of teachers influence teachers absenteeism in public primary schools in Migori, to determine the relationship between leadership styles and teachers absenteeism in Public schools in Migori and to determine the effect of job satisfaction on teacher absenteeism in Public schools in Migori. The study adopted a descriptive research design and targeted 5 public primary schools in Migori. The target population comprised of 365 teachers in the five schools identified. A sample size of 110 respondents was selected from the target population using stratified random sampling……

CHAPTER I

This chapter should be on a new page.

1.1 Background to the study.
   - Under this section, create the readers interest in the topic by providing a basis for your research issue and problem.
   - Specifically, it should establish the problem leading to the study.
   - You may discuss the deficiency in the literature about the problem, showing why the problem to be investigated in the study is significant. Show the gaps that has have not been done.

1.2 Statement of the problem should be precise and focused. Should not exceed 300

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Words.

1.3 Objectives of the study should be directly linked to the study variables as indicated in the chosen title of the study.The section may be arranged as:

1.3.1 General objective
1.3.2 Specific Objectives

- Use words such as: Identify, explain, justify, analyze, examine, determine, establish etc.

Example

1.3.1 General Objective
The aim of this study was to investigate the factors influencing teacher absenteeism in Public Primary Schools in Migori Constituency.

1.3.2 Specific Objectives
The specific objective of the study was to determine the extent to which social characteristics of teachers influence teachers' absenteeism in public primary schools in Migori constituency.

1.4 Research questions.
Research questions should be derived from the objectives of the study.

1.5 Justification.
Give reason why it is important to study each aspect appearing on the title.

Example
The findings of this study helped the Government and the school administrators develop various ways of motivating the teachers, work on improving the working conditions in the public primary schools……

1.6 Significance.
State the benefits and the beneficiaries of the findings of the study (eg parents , children , the school , community or the government)

1.7 Scope and limitations.

- Outline what you will do.
- Outline what you will not do. eg The area you choose for the study, the population you are not studying.
- Under limitation identify potential weaknesses of the study that may be beyond the capability of the researcher to intervene.
- Explain how you intend to overcome the limitations mentioned.
- What limitations exist in your method, design or approach, sampling restrictions, uncontrollable variables?
- What will limit generalization of your findings?

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Scope example

This study was carried out among on five public schools in Migori. Although there are various public primary schools, this study concentrated on these five Public schools within Migori, because of the high number of students admitted in each school on a yearly basis, as well as the proximity to these schools and the availability of the respondents; who are the teachers, deputy head teachers and head teachers. The focus was on the rates of absenteeism in each school.

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CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE.

2.0 Introduction.

- Provide the structure of the chapter.

2.1 After introduction, the student should begin recognizing other scholars by pointing out what is new in the current research.

- Appropriate theme for this section may be developed using specific objectives of the study.
- Relevant themes to the study and those themes derived from the related literature should be discussed in this section.
- Do not copy paste. Bring out knowledge existing in relation to study problem.
- Bring out the gaps or the areas still not known concerning the title you are studying.
- Show clear gap with regard to knowledge, Methodology, Theory, Scope etc.
- Clearly state how your study will address the identified gaps and hence making your study different from the relevant literature.
- Concentrate on;

❖ Key knowledge issues.
❖ Controversies in literature.
❖ Main research gaps.
❖ The actual gaps that your research will address. 🚌 How these gaps will be addressed.

NB: At least 80% of the literature reviewed should be less than 5 years old.

- What are the views of other researchers based on the results or findings of their study?
- The guiding questions are; 🚌 What did they do ?
  ❖ How did they do it?
  ❖ What population, strategy, and method did they use?
  ❖ What did they do wrongly?
  ❖ What did they find out?

NB: Your work in the section is to quote, paraphrase, summarize and evaluate.

ETHICAL ISSUES IN RESEARCH.

The term „Ethics‟ is derived from the Greek word „ethos‟ meaning „character‟.

1. What moral principles guide your research?
2. How do ethical issues influence your selection of a research problem?
3. How do ethical issues affect how you conduct your research? The design of your study, your sampling procedure etc.
4. What responsibilities do you have towards your research subject? eg Do you have their informed consent to participate in your project/proposal research.

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5. What ethical issues / dilemmas might come into play in deciding what research findings you publish?
6. Will your research directly benefit those who participated in the study?

DEFINITIONS:

- „Research ethics" refers to a set of values, standards and institutional schemes that help regulate scientific activity.
- It refers to standards related to research process, including relationship between researchers, individual and institution being studied.
- All research in teaching and learning environment are conducted with the participation of human beings or have an impact on human beings or the wider society and the environment. Therefore it is important that all researchers understand ethical issues and the implications of their research on individuals (subjects), the wider society and the environment.
- Ethical considerations are the basic set of rules, principles which a researcher should follow in the course of the whole research.
- It refers to human values, norms and societal arrangements that regulate the whole research process.

DEFINITION OF TERMS.

i. **Plagiarism:** Refers to the copying of the materials or the use of other people"s data without acknowledgement and the use of ideas from other people as if it were one"s own.
ii. **Foot notes:** Refers to content copied without any changes.
iii. **Research proposal:** A detailed written plan that……. How a research project is to be carried out.
iv. **Research report**: A straight forward document that is meant to communicate to the reader clearly and precisely what has been gathered in a given topic of study.
v. **Research problem**: This is an area of concern/interest which a researcher may need to study to help find solutions or answers to it. A question or an issue for which research is necessary.
vi. **Data**: Facts/information used to find out things or for decision making.
vii. **Analysis**: Refers to the detailed study/examination of information in order to understand more about it.

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